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FOR SUBHASH CHANDRA, 72, facing challenges is a way of life. From staving off a takeover bid by Rupert Murdoch in the late 1990s to setting up the ill-fated rebel cricket league ICL, the home-grown entrepreneur—who made his name as the Founder of Zee TV—may well have lost count of how many he has faced. And he has emerged unscathed in most instances, though he has lost a big chunk of his shareholding in Zee Entertainment Enterprises Ltd (or ZEEL, that had revenues of ₹8,170 crore for FY23) and is the crown jewel of his Essel Group.

The present challenge is quite a different story, though. He is dealing with a host of serious allegations from capital markets regulator Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) around corporate governance. This will test Chandra's mettle—and that of his son Punit Goenka—and he will have to



SUBHASH CHANDRA, Chairman Emeritus, Zee Entertainment Enterprises

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draw upon his wisdom from many a battle to deal with it. For the man who got into television broadcasting without a background in the business—and carved out an empire—competition has come from several quarters and it did make a dent, but Chandra managed to hang on. The ability to think out of the box stood him in good stead earlier. Will that help him this time?

TOUGH TIMES

For ZEEL, which was in the thick of a merger (more on this later) with Sony Pictures Network India (now called Culver Max Entertainment), the interim order from Sebi on June 12 was a bolt from the blue. Referring to an issue that dates back to September 2018, it said Chandra and his son Goenka (MD & CEO of ZEEL) had abused their board posi-